

Money makes you rich free

I came to this realisation at a party. I was 13 years old, and my family and I were at a celebration for a wealthy family friend who had recently started a business. I didn't feel particularly money-minded then and, if anything, this uncle always seemed to be worried and busy. I associated money with evil and guilt — it was something that had to be taken off the backs of other people. On some level I believed that there was only so much money available, so for you to make money it had to be taken away from someone else. That would not be me. I didn't want to be considered 'money minded'. I personally wanted to spend my time enjoying my life, not chasing dollars and cents.

A woman I had never met came over and, in true 'aunty' fashion, asked me about my future and what I wanted to do with my life. I can't remember a lot of what she said in that conversation in between mentioning multiple times that her son was in medical school, but one thing did prick up my ears: she said I really needed to study hard, get a well-paying job and become financially independent. Because then, 'no matter what happens in your life, whether it be a bad job or a relationship, you can walk away and say no'.

I thought about that conversation a lot after the party. I hate to admit that, eventually, I forgot her name, I forgot what she looked like, what she was wearing and where the party was held, but I never forgot what she said. In order to have more control in my life, in order to have the freedom to live in alignment with my goals and values, and in order to be able to walk away from situations that did not serve me, I needed to be financially free.

I realised it wasn't wrong to care about or be 'focused on' money. Money affects every aspect of our lives. It affects our life expectancy, our health outcomes, our access to better resources. It affects our stress and mental health, our relationships with our families, partners and children. It affects our ability to enjoy our day-to-day activities, but, more importantly, it affects our freedom, our choices and what control we have over our lives.